

The Little Lantern

A warm story about finding courage in small places.

by JoeOkat

Read at your level. Grow at your pace.

Every story includes useful vocabulary and clear language so you can
improve naturally.

Nima lived with her grandmother at the edge of a large forest. Their house was small and made of wood, but it was warm and comfortable. There were trees behind the house, a small garden in front, and a narrow path that led into the forest. Nima loved the forest during the day because she could hear birds singing and see butterflies flying between the flowers. At night, however, the forest looked very different.

Nima's grandmother was an old woman who knew many stories about the forest. She often sat beside the window in the evening and told Nima about the people who had lived there many years ago. Sometimes she talked about hunters, farmers, and travelers who had walked through the forest. Nima listened carefully because she loved her grandmother's stories, even when some of them made the forest sound a little frightening.

One evening, Grandmother did not feel well. Her face was hot, and she looked tired as she sat in her chair. Nima became worried and brought her some water. "Are you okay, Grandmother?" she asked.

"I will be fine," Grandmother replied, although her voice was weak. She drank the water slowly and then looked at Nima. "But I need some medicine, and we do not have any here."

"Where can we get it?" Nima asked.

"You must go to Old Tamsin," Grandmother said. "She lives on the other side of the forest, and she has medicine for me."

Nima looked towards the window. It was already getting dark outside. The thought of walking through the forest at night made her nervous. "Do I have to go now?" she asked quietly.

Grandmother smiled and reached under her bed. She brought out an old lantern and placed it in Nima's hands. The lantern was small, but it was strong, and its glass was still clear.

"Take this with you," Grandmother said. "It will help you see the path."

Nima held the lantern tightly. "But I am afraid."

Grandmother looked at her for a moment before speaking. "Everyone is scared sometimes. Courage does not mean that you have no fear. Courage means that you keep walking even when you are afraid."

Nima looked at the lantern again. She took a deep breath and stood up. "All right. I will go."

"Be careful," Grandmother said. "And come back as soon as you can."

Nima stepped outside with the lantern in her hand. The evening air was cool, and the wind moved gently through the trees. She could hear the leaves making a soft sound above her, while the last light of the day disappeared behind the hills.

At first, Nima walked quickly because she wanted to reach Old Tamsin's house before it became completely dark. She knew the path well, but at night it seemed longer than usual. Every tree looked bigger, and every sound made her stop and listen.

For a moment, she thought about going back home. Then she remembered what Grandmother had said, so she held the lantern higher and continued walking.

"Just a little further," she whispered to herself.

Soon, she heard a strange sound above her. Nima stopped and looked up. An owl was sitting on a branch, watching her with large, bright eyes. Nima jumped, but the owl simply opened its wings and flew quietly into the darkness.

Nima smiled nervously. "You scared me."

She continued along the path, and after a while she began to see tiny lights moving between the trees. They were fireflies. Their small lights appeared and disappeared as they moved through the dark forest, and Nima stopped for a moment to watch them.

The forest did not seem quite as frightening now.

A little later, Nima heard water running nearby. She followed the sound until she reached a small wooden bridge. The bridge was old, and some of the wood looked weak. Nima carefully stepped onto it and held the lantern close to her.

"Be careful," she whispered.

She walked slowly across the bridge, one step at a time. When she reached the other side, she looked back and smiled. She had crossed it safely.

At last, she saw a small house with a warm light shining through the window. Nima knew she had arrived.

She knocked on the door, and an old woman opened it. "Who is there?" she asked.

"It is Nima," she replied. "My grandmother is sick, and she needs medicine."

Old Tamsin looked at the lantern in Nima's hand and then smiled. "Come inside. You must be tired."

Nima entered the house and explained what had happened. Old Tamsin listened carefully before taking a small bottle from a wooden shelf.

"Give this to your grandmother," she said. "It should help her feel better."

"Thank you," Nima said. She held the bottle carefully. "I must go home now."

"It is very dark outside," Old Tamsin said. "Would you like to stay here tonight?"

Nima thought about it for a moment, but she shook her head. "Thank you, but Grandmother is waiting for me."

Old Tamsin smiled. "Then go carefully, and keep your lantern close."

Nima thanked her and stepped outside again. The forest was still dark, but she did not feel the same fear as before. She knew the path now, and the little lantern gave her enough light to see where she was going.

As she walked, Nima heard the owl again. This time, she did not jump. She simply looked up and smiled.

"Good evening," she said.

The owl flew from one tree to another as Nima continued towards home. The fireflies were still moving between the trees, and the sound of the wind followed her along the path.

When Nima finally saw the light from her grandmother's window, she felt very happy. She walked faster and opened the door.

"Grandmother, I am back!"

Grandmother looked up from her chair. "Nima!"

Nima ran to her and gave her the medicine. "Here it is. Old Tamsin gave it to me."

Grandmother held Nima's hand and smiled. "You came back safely."

"Yes," Nima said. "I was afraid, but I kept walking."

Grandmother looked at the old lantern and then at Nima. "Then you have learned something important tonight."

"What?"

"Fear and courage can walk together," Grandmother said. "You do not need to stop being afraid before you can be brave."

Nima looked through the window at the dark forest. It no longer seemed like a terrible place. It was still dark, and there were still strange sounds among the trees, but she knew she could walk through it.

She placed the lantern beside the window so that its small light could shine into the night.

It was a small light in a small place, but it was enough.

Always enough.

Glossary

Lantern: a small light that people can carry

Courage: being brave, even when you feel afraid

Forest: a large area of trees, like a big wood

Medicine: something you take to feel better when you are sick

Firefly: a small insect that produces light.

Whisper: to say something very quietly

Path: a small road or way that people can walk on.

Weak: not strong.

Afraid: feeling fear or worry.

Useful Expressions

1. **Are you okay?**

French: Est-ce que tu vas bien ?

Used when you want to ask if someone is well or has a problem.

2. **I will be fine.**

French: Je vais bien aller.

Used to say that you will be okay.

3. **I am afraid.**

French: J'ai peur.

Used when you feel fear.

4. **Don't worry.**

French: Ne t'inquiète pas.

Used to tell someone not to be afraid or concerned.

5. **Be careful.**

French: Fais attention.

Used when you want someone to take care or avoid danger.

6. **Come inside.**

French: Entre.

Used when you invite someone to enter a place.

7. **Thank you.**

French: Merci.

Used when you want to show that you are grateful.

8. **Just a little further.**

French: Encore un petit peu.

Used when something is not far away.

9. **For a moment.**

French: Pendant un moment.

Used to talk about a short period of time.

10. **At last.**

French: Enfin.

Used when something happens after waiting or travelling for some time.

11. **A little later.**

French: Un peu plus tard.

Used to talk about something that happens after a short time.

12. **I must go home.**

French: Je dois rentrer à la maison.

Used when you need to return home.

13. **I am back.**

French: Je suis de retour.

Used when you have returned to a place.

14. **Take your time.**

French: Prends ton temps.

Used to tell someone that they do not need to hurry.

15. **Thank goodness!**

French: Dieu merci !

Used to show that you are happy or relieved because something bad did not happen.

Let's Practice

Be careful.

"Be careful. The road is wet."

Are you okay?

"You look tired. Are you okay?"

Don't worry.

"Don't worry. I can help you."

I am back.

"Hello, Grandmother. I am back."

At last.

"At last, we arrived at the village."